



National Institute of  
Diabetes and Digestive  
and Kidney Diseases

# Symptoms & Causes of Gestational Diabetes

## What are the symptoms of gestational diabetes?

Usually, gestational diabetes has no symptoms. If you do have symptoms, they may be mild, such as being thirstier than normal or having to urinate more often.

## What causes gestational diabetes?

Gestational diabetes occurs when your body can't make the extra [insulin](#) needed during pregnancy. Insulin, a [hormone](#) made in your [pancreas](#), helps your body use [glucose](#) for energy and helps control your blood glucose levels.

During pregnancy, your body makes special hormones and goes through other changes, such as weight gain. Because of these changes, your body's cells don't use insulin well, a condition called **insulin resistance**. All pregnant women have some insulin resistance during late pregnancy. Most pregnant women can produce enough insulin to overcome insulin resistance, but some cannot. These women develop gestational diabetes.



Pregnant women who can't make enough insulin during late pregnancy develop gestational diabetes.

Being [overweight](#) or having [obesity](#) is linked to gestational diabetes. Women who are overweight or have obesity may already have insulin resistance when they become pregnant. Gaining too much weight during pregnancy may also be a factor.

Having a family history of diabetes makes it more likely that a woman will develop gestational diabetes, which suggests that [genes](#) play a role.

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